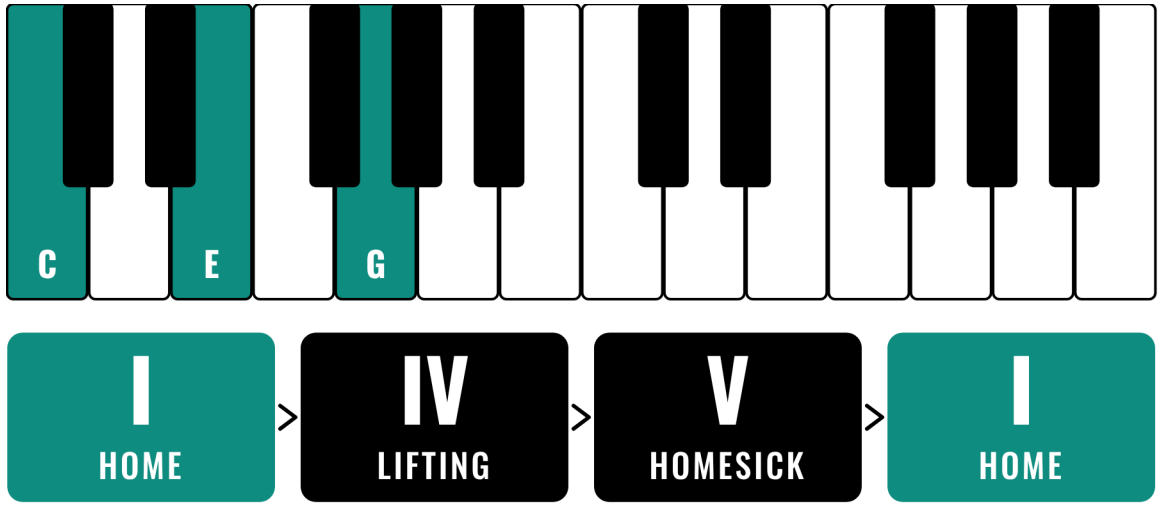
HUDSON BEAT



CHORDS BY EAR

Feat. Twist and Shout

WHAT THE HECK IS A CHORD?

- Three or more notes played at the same time
- Notes from the scale, stacked together
- Major sounds bright. Minor sounds dark.
- Today: no names. Just your ears.

LISTEN: ONE NOTE, THEN A CHORD

C › C–E–G › A–C–E

teacher plays on a piano sound

Play a single C. Then C major. Then A minor.

- What does one note feel like?
- What changed when it became a chord?
- What is different about the third one?

LISTEN: FOUR CHORDS IN A ROW

C–E–G › F–A–C › G–B–D › C–E–G

slowly, then on a loop

Play the four chords slowly, then loop them.

- What happened at the end?
- Which chord wanted to go somewhere?
- Why does the last one feel finished?

LISTEN: A REAL SONG

TWIST AND SHOUT

The Beatles

Teacher: play the first minute from YouTube or Spotify.

- How many different chords do you hear?
- Which one feels like home?
- When does it want to go back?

YOUR TURN: PLAY AND DESCRIBE

Play each one on a piano sound. Write what it feels like in your own words. Bright or dark?

C–E–G

Chord 1 · feels like…

F–A–C

Chord 2 · feels like…

G–B–D

Chord 3 · feels like…

A–C–E

Chord 4 · feels like…

D–F–A

Chord 5 · feels like…

E–G–B

Chord 6 · feels like…

B–D–F

Chord 7 · feels like…

SAME CHORDS, A DIFFERENT HOME

LOOP 1

Home: the first and last chord

C–E–G on a loop

F–A–C on a loop

G–B–D on a loop

C–E–G on a loop

LOOP 2

Where is home now?

A–C–E on a loop

F–A–C on a loop

C–E–G on a loop

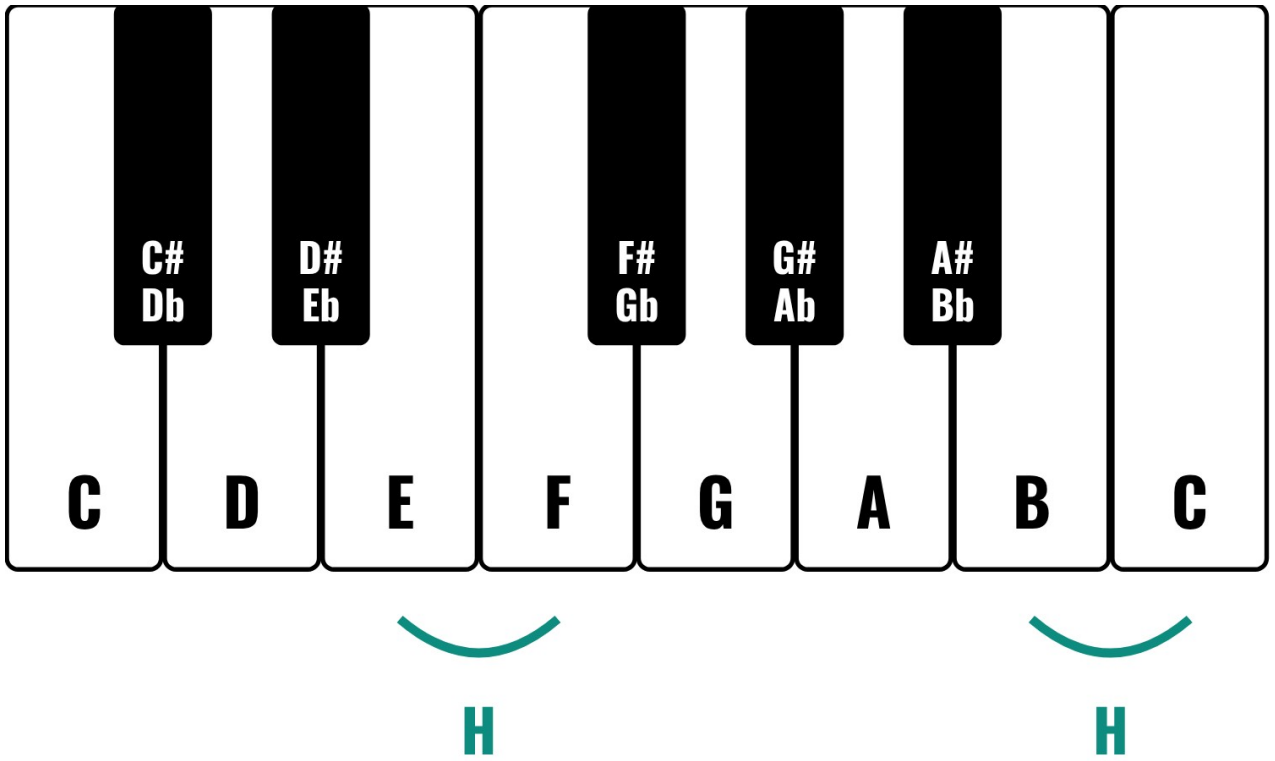
G–B–D on a loop

Same white keys, nearly the same chords. A different home.

YOUR WORDS ARE MUSIC THEORY

- “That one sounds like something good is about to happen.”
- “That one sounds unfinished.”
- Write the class’s words on the board
- On Day 4 they get shorter names

THE KEYBOARD



Find C: just left of every group of 2 black keys.

HALF STEP (H)

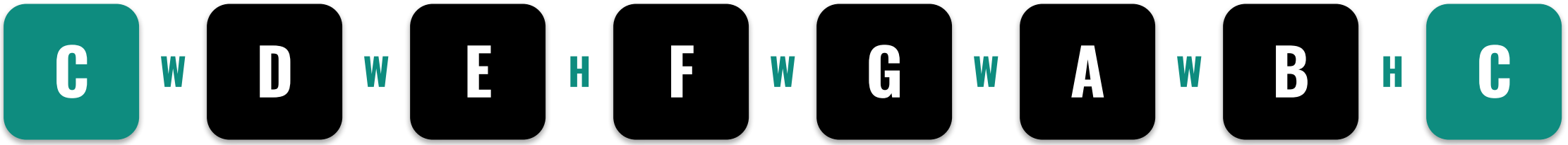
One key in either direction, black keys included. E to F and B to C are the only white-key half steps.

WHOLE STEP (W)

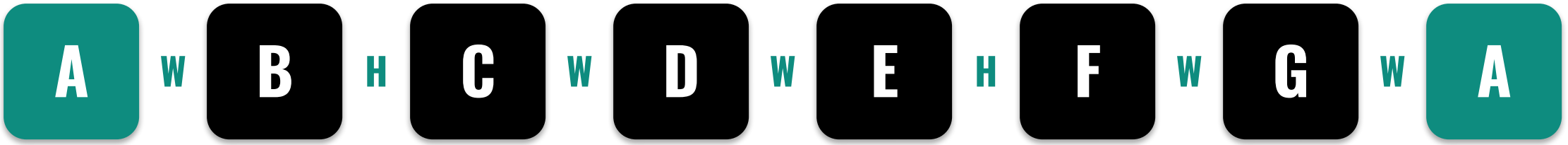
Two half steps: skip one key. C to D, D to E, G to A.

SCALES: THE INGREDIENT LIST

C MAJOR · W - W - H - W - W - W - H



A NATURAL MINOR · W - H - W - W - H - W - W



Same seven white keys, a different starting note, a different feel.

YOUR PROJECT: CHORDS & ROMAN NUMERALS

DAY 1

CHORDS BY EAR: JUST LISTEN

Play seven chords and describe them in your own words; hear I–IV–V–I come home

DAY 2

THE KEYBOARD AND SCALES

Name every key; half steps and whole steps; build the C major and A minor scales

DAY 3

BUILD CHORDS FROM FORMULAS · PROJECT

Build major, minor and diminished chords from formulas; enter them in the piano roll

DAY 4

ROMAN NUMERALS + REFERENCE CARD · PROJECT

Roman numerals = names for feelings; KCSRN + Reference Card; chords over the bassline

DAY 5

BALANCE, FINISH, PRESENT · PROJECT

Balance the chords under the bass; finish, submit and present

WHAT YOU TURN IN

- [ ] Chord pages + Roman numeral section of the packet
- [ ] Reference Card for your key
- [ ] 4 chords in Logic, one per measure
- [ ] Each region labeled with its Roman numeral
- [ ] Chord function table filled in
- [ ] MP3 + .zip, named Your Name — Building Blocks Part 3

HOW IT'S SCORED

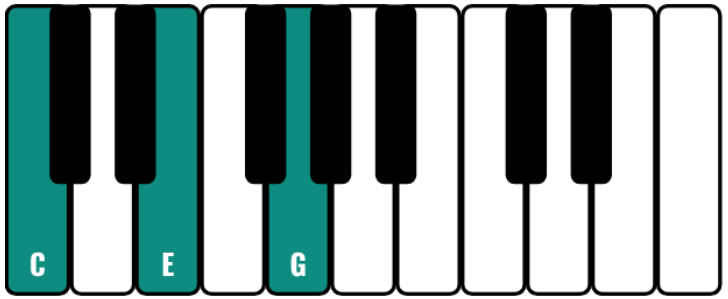
CHORD CONSTRUCTION	5 = All chords correct, well-voiced and labeled with Roman numerals.	/ 5
HARMONIC UNDERSTANDING	5 = Specific, accurate descriptions; knows why each chord was chosen.	/ 5
DOCUMENTATION & PRESENTATION	5 = Named correctly, on time; explains choices in Roman numeral language.	/ 5

SCORED 2 TO 5 · TOTAL / 15

BUILD A CHORD: COUNT HALF STEPS

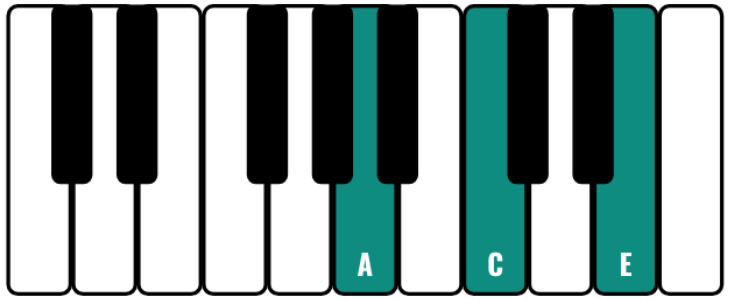
C MAJOR

R-4-3 · C - E - G



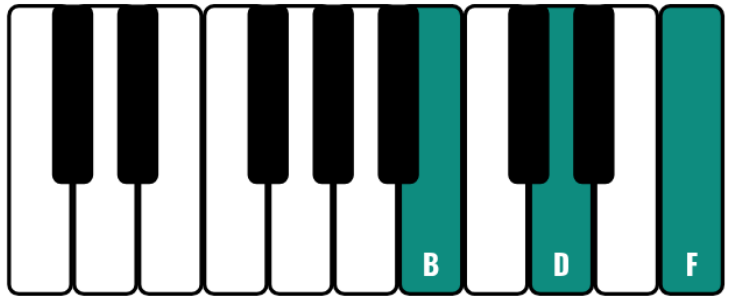
A MINOR

R-3-4 · A - C - E



B DIM.

R-3-3 · B - D - F



MAJOR: R - 4 - 3

bright and stable

MINOR: R - 3 - 4

darker and more emotional

DIMINISHED: R - 3 - 3

tense and unstable

Do not count the root: for C, C# is 1. C-E-G = 4 up, then 3 up.

WATCH ME: A CHORD IN THE PIANO ROLL

1. New software instrument track, a piano sound
2. Draw an empty MIDI region, one measure long
3. Open the piano roll and add C, E and G
4. Same start, same length: stacked, not a melody
5. Play it. Name the region.

ROMAN NUMERALS = NAMES FOR FEELINGS

I – IV – V – I = HOME, AWAY, VERY AWAY, HOME

I

Home. Settled. Complete.

IV

Lifting. Hopeful. Away from home.

V

Homesick. Wants to resolve to I.

vi

Tender. Melancholy. Emotional.

Uppercase = major · lowercase = minor · ° = diminished. A letter name tells you the notes; a Roman numeral tells you the job.

LISTEN: FIND THE TENDER CHORD

LET IT BE

The Beatles

Teacher: play the first minute from YouTube or Spotify.

- Four chords: I, V, vi, IV
- Which one is home?
- Which one feels tender?

YOUR REFERENCE CARD

C MAJOR — W - W - H - W - W - W - H

RN	CHORD	NOTES	FEELS LIKE...
I	C Major	C - E - G	Home. Settled. Complete.
ii	D Minor	D - F - A	Gentle tension. Moving somewhere.
iii	E Minor	E - G - B	Wistful. In between.
IV	F Major	F - A - C	Lifting. Hopeful. Away from home.
V	G Major	G - B - D	Homesick. Wants to resolve to I.
vi	A Minor	A - C - E	Tender. Melancholy. Emotional.
vii°	B Dim.	B - D - F	Tense. Unstable. Rarely used alone.

WORKED EXAMPLE: CHORDS OVER THE BASSLINE

	I C Major	vi A Minor	IV F Major	V G Major
CHORDS	G	E	C	D
	E	C	A	B
	C	A	F	G
BASS	C	A	F	G
	Measure 1	Measure 2	Measure 3	Measure 4

Teal: the chords you build (3 notes stacked). Black: the bassline in the file. Every chord's root = the bass note.

MIXING MOMENT: BALANCE

- Solo the chords, then the bass, then both
- Which one should the listener follow?
- Turn the chords down until the bass is clear
- Turning down is a musical decision

ONE LAST THING...

- Point to your I chord.
- Play it. Does it feel like home?
- That is the test.

